

With what degree?

History.

What were your career objectives at the time?

I didn't have any thoughts at all. After I graduated, I thought I would try my luck getting a job in Australia for a year or so, but unbeknownst to me, Australia was in an even worse recession than we were. I came back after six months and ended up finding a job as an accountant at PricewaterhouseCoopers.

Did you have any accounting background?

No, none at all.

I'm surprised that they would hire you without any accounting background.

I would look at it another way. People who choose to go for an accounting degree at the age of 17 have limited intellectual heft and imagination. If you are 17 and want to be an accountant, how sad is that? High-level auditing is more about opinion than nuts and bolts. So you don't necessarily want someone who just looks at nuts and bolts because they're not going to get the big picture. That is why I think the London accounting firms recruit people from across disciplines rather than just accounting majors.

How did you get your education in accounting?

The way it works in the U.K. is different from the way it does in the U.S. In the U.K., for a three-year period, you work full time and study in the evening, taking exams at the end of each year, and qualifying at the end of the period. The only difference if you have an accounting degree is that you get an automatic pass on the first year exam.

It doesn't sound like you had any particular desire to be an accountant, though.

My thinking was that as an accountant I would get to audit different businesses, which I thought might give me some ideas of what I wanted to do on a more permanent basis. By pure chance, I was assigned to a group that audited investment banks, stockbrokers, and asset managers.